Bachelor Thesis

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Chapter 1

Introduction

Over the last 20 years there was a major leap in robotics, especially in the field of quadrupeds. Many great papers developing the domain were published. And most of the researching work was done in labs, requiring great means for prototyping and pushing the boundaries of the domain. In this paper, I would like to review the research and practical achievements that have been done throughout the years and combine it in a project, the cost of which will be less. The idea is to establish a base for low-cost quadruped robots to make them more affordable for day-to-day use in different fields of human lives.

1.1 Literature review

There is a number of "classical" papers that can be used to lay the foundation for this project. They vary from gaits and control to computer vision and successful real-world examples.

The most important thing for a quadruped robot is locomotion. The mathematical analysis in the 1968 "On the stability properties of quadruped creeping gaits" Mathematical Biosciences journal article shows, that there is "a unique optimum gait that maximizes static stability". The work explains that for static stability the center of gravity must be within the support polygon. This shape is formed by connecting all feet that touch the ground (contact points). Though, stability can be achived by dynamic means as well. The concept of dynamic stability is discussed in the 1984 "Experiments in Balance with a 3D One-Legged Hopping Machine", which explains the control algorithms: forward velocity, body altitude, and hopping height.

In the recent years, compute became more accessible and the development of neural networks allowed to creation of simulated environments, in which ditigal versions of robots were put in and given a task to arrive from point A to B without being programmed to do so using Deep Reinforcement Learning (DRL). This approach was used in 2019 "Learning Agile and Dynamic Motor Skills for Legged Robots" for ANYmal robot. The researchers applied the real-world behavior of the robot's motors to the simulation that allowed the simulation to be more realistic and helped the robot learn imperfect nuances of the world.

While the theoretical foundations establish how quadruped locomotion works, several landmark systems demonstrate what is achievable with mature engineering. Boston Dynamics' BigDog (2008) was the first to demonstrate load-carrying dynamic locomotion on rough terrain, proving quadrupeds could operate in real-world conditions outside the lab. It was a direct descendant of the 1984 hopping machine experiments and it made evident that dynamic stability is the key to traversing challenging terrain. Similarly, MIT's Cheetah 3 (2018) showed that model-based control could achieve robust blind locomotion over obstacles. These systems represented the state-of-the-art capability of quadruped robots at their time. The projects were sponsored by DARPA and MIT respectively and did not focus on cost reduction, but rather on pushing the boundaries of what quadruped robots could do.

Chapter 2

Methodology

2.1 Methods and technologies used

2.1.1 Project requirements

2.1.2 Technologies selection

2.1.3 Models

Chapter 3

Results

Chapter 4

Conclusion

Chapter 5

Future work

Reference list

1. BigDog, the Rough-Terrain Quadruped Robot 2. MIT Cheetah 3: Design and Control of a Robust, Dynamic Quadruped Robot 3. On the stability properties of quadruped creeping gaits 4. Experiments in Balance with a 3D One-Legged Hopping Machine 5. Learning Agile and Dynamic Motor Skills for Legged Robots